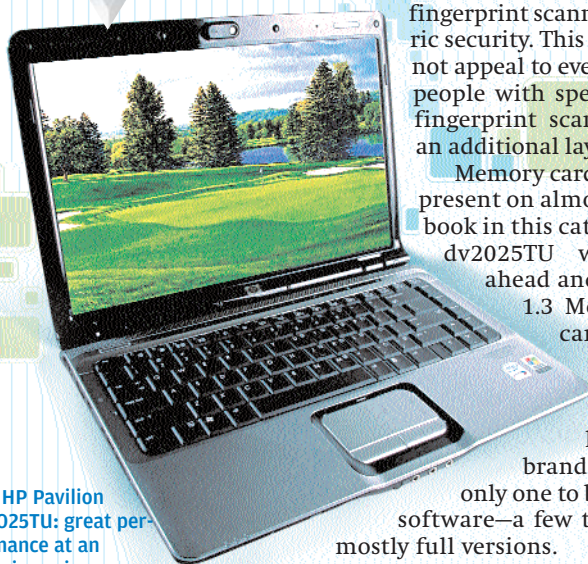


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The HP Pavilion dv2025TU: great performance at an amazing price

some stray 80 GBs. Ideally, anything over 60 GB is a luxury, unless you need to store a huge collection of movies and songs. Not all models come with DVD-Writers—the ASUS Z35H, Dell Inspiron 640m, Gigabyte W511U, TCL K41, and Toshiba Tecra A8 offer just a combo drive.

Very few laptops came with Bluetooth inbuilt, whereas almost all of them supported the faster b+g Wi-Fi standard.

The Toshiba Tecra A8 and LG's XNote T1 and P1 were the only ones with a fingerprint scanner for biometric security. This feature might not appeal to everyone, but for people with specific needs, a fingerprint scanner provides an additional layer of security.

Memory card readers were present on almost every notebook in this category. The HP dv2025TU went a step

ahead and integrated a 1.3 Megapixel Web camera, which works quite well, on the laptop lid. Of all the brands, HP was the only one to bundle tons of software—a few trialware, but mostly full versions.

Performance

Application performance

Loaded with the best hardware, the ASUS V6000J was expected to deliver, and it did. However, the Dell Inspiron 6400 was neck-and-neck with the V6000J in almost all the tests, at times setting scores better than the V6000J. In fact, the Dell Inspiron was better at memory utilisation—this is confirmed by its Si-Soft Sandra scores and the ZD-Bench Business Winstone benchmark.

Despite its 1 GB advantage, the ASUS V6000J loses the performance crown to the Dell Inspiron 6400 by a small margin. The other ASUS sibling, the Z35H, comes out as the third-best performer of the lot.

The HP dv2025TU, Toshiba Tecra A8, LG XNote T1 and Gigabyte W551N are tied for

fourth position. These notebooks had similar hardware, and their scores are nearly identical.

Battery life

When it comes to battery life, LG's Xnote T1 has the performance to match its award-winning looks. This notebook was able to stretch the battery to an amazing four hours. In our gruelling DVD file playback test, that score is fantastic; this laptop should run at least an hour more when regular applications are used. The HP DV2025, ASUS V6000J, and Dell Inspiron 6400 offer the next-best battery life of around two and a half hours.

Overall, as far as performance goes, Dell's Inspiron 6400 came out tops as the undisputed leader. Its superb hardware enabled it to sail smoothly through most of our tests, and the longer battery life is the icing on the cake.

Our Conclusion

The Dell Inspiron 6400, with its fabulous hardware, not only works out as the greatest performer; its sensible pricing, too, makes it the best buy. The only area where it falls a little short of our expectations was the look and feel—it's not a particularly sleek-looking notebook.

While the ASUS V6000J has great hardware and performance, it is priced on the higher side. At Rs 1,05,540, the price does justify the product, but better products such as the Dell Inspiron play spoilsport on ASUS' attempt to provide the best combination of price and performance.

The HP Pavilion dv2025TU, with its steady performance, great looks and equally impressive performance, came out as the overall second-best amongst the usual suspects, and Dell's Inspiron 6400 does manage to sneak in on to the podium for third place.

ZEN AND THE ART OF BONSAI

While the term "ultra-portable" reminds us of the 10-inch notebooks from Sony, Toshiba, and Fujitsu, most manufacturers now have at least one model in their line-up for frequent fliers.

The ultra-portables' power consumption and screen dimensions have evolved to make them better suitable to handle newer, resource-hungry applications—screen sizes have gone up

Gaming On The Move

Breaking the barriers of graphics performance are the gaming laptops from some very reputed companies. Leading the pack is Alienware, with the distinction of being the first company to build SLI notebooks. Alienware's Aurora MALX series is the most powerful laptop series in the world in terms of graphics performance. You get to choose from a wide range of GPUs from the NVIDIA family, but the dual GeForce Go 7900GTX, with a total memory of 1 GB, rules them all. A huge 19-inch widescreen display lets you enjoy and admire the true power of these beasts. To carry all your music, videos, and games, this behemoth can have two hard disks in RAID 0 configuration, with a maximum storage space of 240 GB. Currently, this series is powered by AMD's older Turion series of CPUs, but it would be really interesting to see the performance once Alienware starts

shipping similar notebooks with Core 2 Duos. In short, it'll have enough power to kick any Desktop around. These custom-made laptops look better than mass-produced laptops—just like an F1 car looks and performs better than a family car! With a base price of \$4,499 (Rs 2,11,000), a comparison between the two car types is befitting.

Dell has also started looking towards gaming laptops with its XPS series. This series is actually not purely gaming-oriented—it lies somewhere between the gaming and lifestyle laptops.

With Dell having acquired Alienware in the recent past, we hope they will capitalise on Alienware's expertise in the high-performance gaming arena to bring out faster and more stunning laptops.